

Let's face one thing – clock speeds aren't as important as they used to be. Intel and AMD are moving away from raw speed and focussing on adding other performance-boosting features to their CPUs. Faster caches, more cores, larger caches, lower latencies, the ability for one

CPU core to work on two threads (called Hyperthreading or HT by Intel), automatic higher clocking of a single core, when other cores are idle, improved registers, to name but a few. You need to be savvy when choosing a processor, what suited your friend's needs, may not suit yours.

I took a trip to Lamington Road, Mumbai's hardware hub, disguised as a clueless shopper. Deliberately staying away from the smaller, one-man-show shopkeepers, who would recognise me and clam up when I asked for information, I threaded my way through the first street, until I came to a junction. My mission was thus – I was shopping for the cheapest CPU offering bang-for-buck. And I wasn't going to settle for less than a dual core. I was also looking for something the ideal CPU within a price range of Rs. 8,500 – which is similar to the budget of a lot of readers writing in. Finally, I wanted to see which CPU was hot, when it came to sheer performance, but for a goodly budget of Rs. 15,000 – and I wasn't going to spend a penny err paisa more.

A few vendors believed that AMD could not be beaten, when it came to extreme value. They were quick to point out to the AMD Athlon x2 6000+ - which although a 3 GHz part, is an older CPU. One guy showed me the Athlon II X2 240 and 250. The former is priced at Rs. 2,999, and is a new 45nm part, running at 2.8 GHz and with 2 MB L2 cache. Indeed, this CPU is quite the beast, for it outperforms any Intel CPU in that price range. I also came across the Intel Pentium Dual Core E5200 and E5300, and while the price was similar, these cannot match the X2 240 in terms of performance. This CPU, in my opinion, is perfect for anyone looking for a good all-round PC or even an HTPC. Some other vendors also spoke about AMDs overheating problems and how customers were complaining. Their solution was to buy an Intel CPU. I beg to differ. I haven't seen any 45nm, AMD CPU heating beyond even 50 degrees, so I have to wonder about the validity of this claim. In fact, for up to 4,000 bucks, you cannot get an Intel CPU that matches AMD in terms of value, and I strongly suggest you do not listen to contrary prattle. AMDs value-for-money dominance

